clan, the Lichchavis received a share of the relics collected from the pyre after he was cremated.

The cadence around the archaeological landscape of Basarh confirms these literary allusions. At the large mound known as Raja Visala ka Garh, a fortified town was revealed, whose twenty-foot wide mud rampart appears to have been constructed around the sixth century BCE.[44] The Abhisheka Pushkarni, a tank that had been used to consecrate the Lichchavi rajas, was also identified with the Kharauna Pokhar which lies less than a couple of kilometres from the garh. In this case, while a wall complex protected the tank, this was apparently a second century BCE construction. There are earlier layers too, their exact antiquity uncertain. The most striking part of the landscape of the Lichchavis is the relic stupa in which they are said to have placed their share of the Buddha's remains. Excavated out of a mound north of the Kharauna Pokhar, the stupa was built in about the fifth century BCE. Constructed of mud, it was subsequently enlarged on four different occasions with bricks. This makes it one of the oldest stupas in India. Made entirely of earth, with as many as twenty-seven mud layers, each separated from the next by a thin layer of gravel, it stood at a height of a little more than three and a half metres with about an eight metre diameter.[45] The original stupa was probably constructed around 550–450 BCE and continued to stand till the first century of the Christian era. The stupa was built on the foundations of an earlier shrine. That edifice, though, was of an entirely different order from the Buddhist monument constructed over it. Its excavated floor has yielded goat bones, which appear to be part of offerings, and for this reason it was described by the excavators as a pre-Buddhist shrine ('chaitya').[46] So, obviously, the Lichchavis used a place that they already considered sacred to create an entirely new kind of hallowed structure over it.

It is, however, the earlier phases of the stupa's construction which concern us here. The mud stupa was said to have been constructed after the